9.4 Smocking

Introduction

Smoking is an embroidery technique that is probably thousands of years old. The name is coined only during 1700's in England. The technique used at the time was gathering. A full work shirt was gathered at the bodice and the sleeves. This gathered effect in the garment was then called a "smock". Smocking was introdced to work man garment mainly to give fullness or free movement of their body and arms. Smocked garments were worn by agricultural laborers, trades men and shepherds in earlier times. In the 19th century smocks were received by artists, to cover their clothing and ladies adapted them in a modified form with fancy embroidery. Later babies clothing, silk under garments for ladies,and even afternoon dresses appeared with smocking. Ladies magazines had instructions for hand smocking and patterns for garments. At present smocking has become the fashion statement.

9.4.1 Types of Smocking

The industrial revolution changed the smocking styles and patterns drastically. There are many types of smocking known throughout the world. The Italians have shirring worked from the back of the fabric, the Romanians have a patterned design using tubes that resemble reeds and other countries stress picture formation over gathered threads done by hand. Smocking basically consists of pleated fabric and a fibre (usually a floss) for embellishment stitches. Pleats are created in two ways;

- A set of dots printed or pressed on the fabric.
- Dots are then used as a gathering guide to create hand pleats (Figure 9.9).

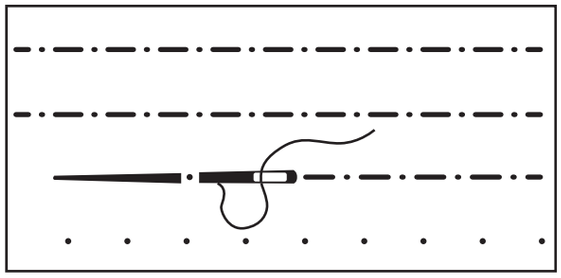


Figure 9.18 Dots Marked on Fabric

- Pleats used in English smocking look like small tubes (Figure 9.10).



Figure 9.19 Fabric tubing

- Small tubes are placed at equi-distant across a the fabric with a thread running through the tubes
- The threads running through the pleats are called as thread guides
- These thread guides are removed after the smocking is completed
- Thread guides should not be visible sometimes these stitches are not

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